Haligric Research Integration Series

TENGRISM

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Sacred Traditions of the Central Asian Steppe — Tengri, Etugen, the World Tree, and the Sacred Shaman

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Tengri is not a god who lives in the sky. Tengri is the sky — the eternal blue sky whose will moves through the universe and through the rulers it chooses.

Genghis Khan credited Tengri with his empire. The bö's drum opens the three worlds.

Suppressed under Buddhism, Islam, and seven decades of Soviet policy, Tengrist practice is now openly revived across Mongolia and Central Asia — and, in Kazakhstan, is being pushed toward formal legal recognition as a religion.

The eternal blue sky is still the eternal blue sky.

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Introduction — Tengrism: The Sacred World of the Steppe

Tengrism (also Tengriism, Tengrizm) is the indigenous sacred tradition of the nomadic and semi-nomadic peoples of the Central Asian steppe — the grassland belt running from the Caspian Sea to Manchuria, from Siberia to the Himalayas and the Iranian plateau. It is the historical sacred framework of the Mongols, the pre-Islamic Turks, the Xiongnu, the Huns, the Uighurs, the pre-Islamic Kazakhs, the Buryats, and numerous related peoples who shared the steppe ecology.

Tengrism has no sacred scripture, no formal clergy in the institutional sense, and no constructed temples — the sky itself is the sacred space. It is a lived relationship between the steppe peoples and the sky, the earth, and the spirit world, maintained through specific ceremony, the bö/kam shaman, and daily acknowledgment. It was the sacred framework through which Genghis Khan understood his conquests, and at the Mongol Empire's peak (1206–1368) it underlay the largest contiguous land empire in history.

Tengri — The Eternal Blue Sky

Tengri (Mongolian: Tenger; Turkic: Tanrı) is the supreme sacred being of the steppe tradition — simultaneously the physical sky and the divine will that determines the fate of peoples and rulers. The Mongolian phrase Möngke Köke Tengri (the Eternal Blue Sky) names this being directly: Tengri is not a god who lives in the sky, Tengri is the sky itself, and the specific vastness, clarity, and silence of a clear day is understood as Tengri's presence made manifest.

Tengri's central activity in human affairs is conferring and withdrawing mandate — the authorization that makes a ruler legitimate. Genghis Khan repeatedly attributed his victories to Tengri's will, a concept structurally parallel to the Chinese Mandate of Heaven, of which the Mongol court was explicitly aware. In more developed theological forms, particularly among the Buryat Mongols, Tengri is elaborated into 99 manifestations — 55 benevolent, 44 challenging — each governing specific domains, paralleling the way other traditions express a single divine will through multiple sacred faces.

Etugen — The Earth Goddess

Etugen (Etugen Eej, 'Mother Etugen') is the earth goddess and Tengri's sacred complement — sky and earth, active and receptive, structurally parallel to the Taoist yin-yang duality, the Hindu Shiva-Shakti pairing, and the Andean Inti-Pachamama relationship. Etugen's body is the steppe itself; offerings are made by pouring libations of milk or airag directly onto the ground, and sacred cairns (ovö, also oboo) at mountain passes and significant landscape features mark points of concentrated earth-power, with travelers customarily adding a stone as they pass.

The Three Worlds and the World Tree

Tengrist cosmology describes three interpenetrating realms connected by a World Tree (Zambi Mod or Daguur Mod) that the shaman uses as an axis of travel: the Upper World, home to Tengri and the higher divine beings; the Middle World, the ordinary human world understood as permeated by spirit presence, including the ongons (spirit beings of specific natural features); and the Lower World, governed by Erlik Khan, ruler of the dead, whom the shaman may need to approach for the most difficult work — retrieving lost souls or negotiating on behalf of the sick.

The Bö/Kam — The Tengrist Shaman

The bö (male shaman; female shamans are udgan) or kam (the Turkic term used across Central Asia) is the central sacred specialist — able to traverse the three worlds and bring their power to bear on the community's needs. The calling comes through near-death illness, specific dreams, or recognition by established shamans, and may be hereditary or spontaneous; in either case it cannot be safely refused. Initiation includes the symbolic death and dismemberment of the ordinary self, the establishment of spirit-helper relationships, and reception of the specific knowledge the role requires. The bö's ceremonial costume — heavy with ornaments, animal parts, and toli (bronze or iron mirrors that both deflect harmful energies and serve as spirit residences) — may weigh 20–30 kilograms and is understood as wearing the spirit world's presence directly.

The Bö Ceremony — Step-by-Step

The bö is called for illness, community disruption, divination, or the calendar's ceremonial requirements. Preparation includes dietary restriction and purification; the drum (hese) is warmed near the fire to activate its resonance and addressed with prayer as a living being. The ceremony opens with libations to Etugen poured around the fire, followed by direct invocation of Tengri; the bö then begins drumming a specific rhythm that calls spirit helpers and initiates the shift toward trance, while songs (udha) invoke specific spirit helpers by name. As the rhythm intensifies the bö enters trance and travels the World Tree to the relevant world — upper for divine consultation, middle for local spirit work, lower for soul retrieval or negotiation with Erlik Khan — accomplishes the ceremony's purpose, and returns to ordinary consciousness as the drumming slows, reporting what was found before the ceremony closes with prayers of gratitude to Tengri, Etugen, and the spirit helpers.

The Tailagan and the Fire Ceremony

The Tailagan (Sky Ceremony) is conducted seasonally, typically spring and autumn, as the community's collective acknowledgment of Tengri: held outdoors, facing north, with white horses or white sheep designated as offerings and libations of airag sprinkled upward to Tengri and downward to Etugen. Fire is the tradition's third primary sacred presence — the fire deity Gal Eej (Fire Mother) mediates between the human and spirit worlds; fire is never stepped over or insulted during ceremony, and specific foods are offered to it with prayer requesting that it carry the community's petitions onward.

Genghis Khan and the Sacred Mandate

The Secret History of the Mongols (c. 1228) opens by stating that Genghis Khan was born with Tengri's blessing, and his victories were attributed to Tengri's will working through him rather than to military genius alone. The Mongol Empire's celebrated religious tolerance — under which Christians, Muslims, Buddhists, Jews, and Taoists all practiced freely alongside Tengrists — was grounded in Tengrist theology itself: if Tengri is the encompassing sky, and different peoples approach the divine through different names and forms, religious persecution is theologically incoherent.

Genghis Khan returned repeatedly to Burkhan Khaldun, a mountain in Mongolia's Khentii range associated with his birth and a near-death escape from enemies, for prayer and consultation with Tengri; he is understood to be buried somewhere on or near the mountain, in a location deliberately concealed. Burkhan Khaldun and its surrounding sacred landscape were inscribed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2015, recognized explicitly for its status as one of the oldest examples of a sacred mountain venerated in Tengrist and shamanic worship, still protected today as a restricted 'forbidden zone' by the Mongolian state.

Suppression Under Buddhism, Islam, and Soviet Rule

Tengrism's dominance receded as Tibetan Buddhism became the majority religious tradition in Mongolia from the sixteenth–seventeenth centuries onward, and as Islam spread through the western Turkic regions of Central Asia — in both cases Tengrist elements persisted underneath the newer tradition rather than disappearing outright, producing durable syncretic practice that continues today. Far more severe was Soviet religious policy across Mongolia and Buryatia in the twentieth century: shamans were executed, imprisoned, or forced underground, sacred sites were destroyed or repurposed, and open practice of Tengrist and shamanic ceremony was suppressed for decades, provoking active resistance including the 1929 Buryat Revolt. Documented post-Soviet revival among the Buryats and in Mongolia since the 1990s has involved shamans and academic researchers working together to reconstruct and re-legitimize practices that Soviet policy had driven into secrecy or silence.

Contemporary Tengrism — Revival and Political Contest

Since the 1990s, Tengrism has undergone open revival across Mongolia and Central Asia: bö and kam ceremonies are practiced publicly, ovö cairns are actively maintained at mountain passes, and airag libations continue at community ceremonies. In Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan, Tengrism's revival has taken an additional, explicitly political dimension: it has been actively promoted since the 2010s–2020s as a marker of pre-Islamic, pre-Russian national identity distinct from both Islam and Soviet secularism, and Kazakhstani advocates have pursued formal legal recognition of Tengrism as an organized religion — a live and unresolved question as of 2025, contested both by religious authorities who see it as invented tradition rather than continuous practice, and by scholars who study 'political Tengrism' as a case study in how contemporary nation-states construct usable ancient pasts.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

Ordinary Tengrist daily life integrates sacred acknowledgment directly into pastoral routine: brief libations before travel or major decisions, the addition of a stone at an ovö when passing, and the ongoing relationship with fire as a living presence in the home. The bö's healing role — addressing illness through soul retrieval, extraction of harmful influence, and negotiation with spirit forces — functions as the community's primary spiritual-health infrastructure in areas where Tengrist practice remains active alongside or independent of Buddhist or biomedical care.

Legacy and Influence

The Mongol Empire remains the largest contiguous land empire in history, built under a sacred framework that held the sky's mandate as sufficient authorization for its expansion and its distinctive religious tolerance. Burkhan Khaldun's 2015 UNESCO inscription formally recognizes Tengrist sacred geography on the same institutional footing as other major world heritage traditions. Tengrism's influence on later Central Asian and Mongolian Buddhist practice, and its ongoing role in Kazakh, Kyrgyz, and Mongolian national identity formation, make it one of the more geopolitically active traditions surveyed in this series.

Controversies and Fairness

Contemporary 'political Tengrism' — its use by Central Asian states and nationalist movements to construct a pre-Islamic, pre-Soviet national identity — is itself contested scholarship: researchers studying the phenomenon (including work specifically on Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tatarstan) describe much of the current institutional push as an 'invention of tradition' serving present-day political legitimacy needs at least as much as it continues unbroken religious practice, a critique some Tengrist practitioners and

revivalists dispute. Kazakhstan's push toward formal legal recognition of Tengrism as an organized religion remains unresolved and contested by established religious authorities.

In Turkey, a distinct and more recent Tengrist revival movement has positioned itself explicitly as an alternative to Islam, framed by some adherents as a return to a authentically Turkic pre-Islamic identity — a position that has drawn both scholarly interest and pushback from religious and nationalist constituencies who see it as a fringe or politically motivated development rather than a restoration of continuous practice.

Soviet-era suppression of Buryat and Mongolian shamanism — executions, imprisonment, and destruction of sacred sites through most of the twentieth century — is well documented and represents one of the most severe state suppressions of any tradition surveyed in this series; post-Soviet revival efforts are ongoing but are working to reconstruct practice and lineage knowledge that was in many cases deliberately and violently broken.

Closing

The bö still stands on the steppe under the eternal blue sky, drums the three worlds open, and rides the World Tree to what cannot be seen from the middle world. Burkhan Khaldun is still a forbidden zone, still protected, still Tengri's mountain. The ovö cairns still gain a stone from every traveler who passes. Whether Tengrism's twenty-first-century revival is understood as an unbroken thread or a reconstructed one — and serious scholars argue both — the eternal blue sky is still, for millions of people across the steppe, the eternal blue sky.